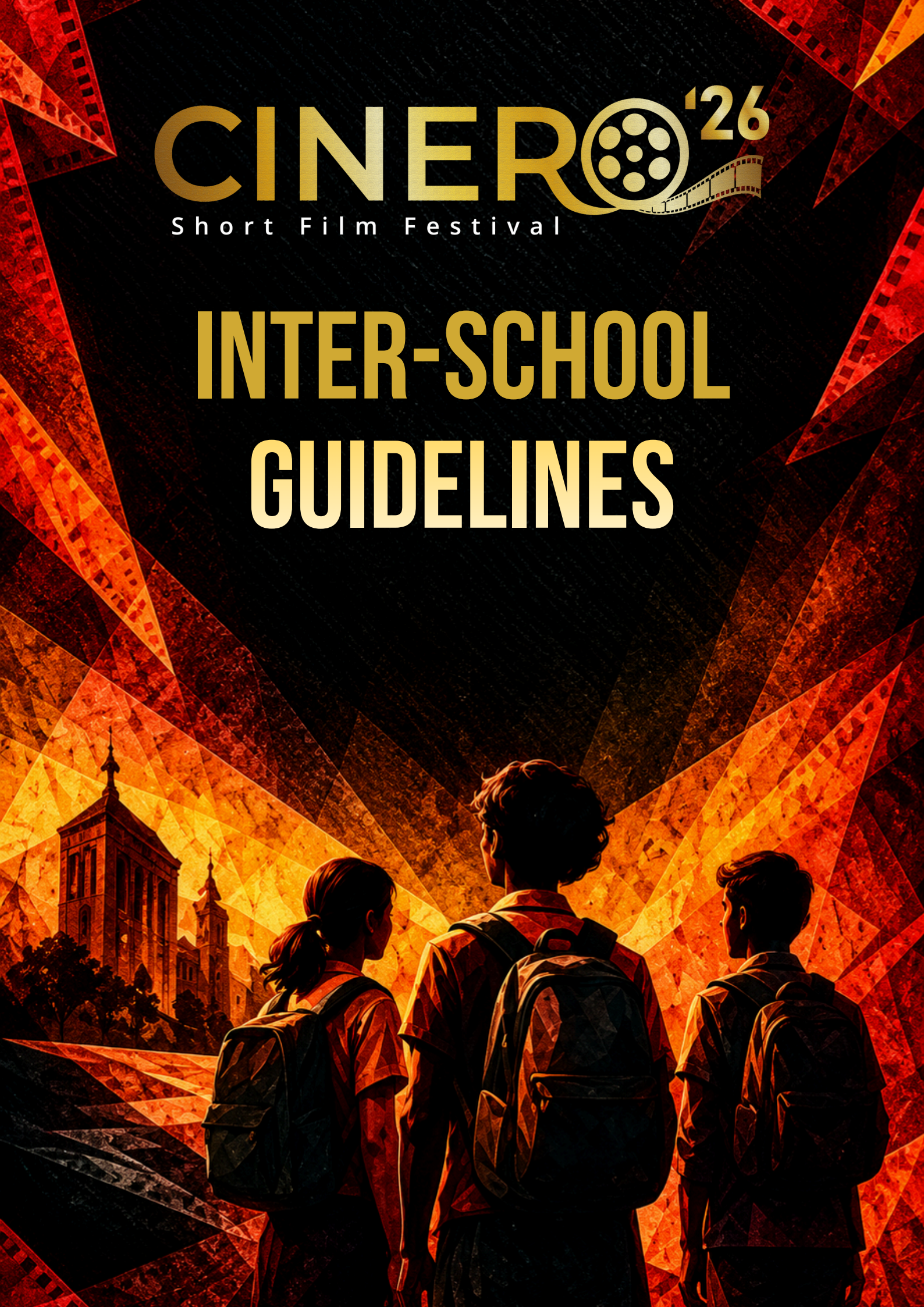
CINERO '26

Short Film Festival

INTER-SCHOOL GUIDELINES



1. FESTIVAL GUIDELINES

Common Rules for Both Categories

REGISTRATION REQUIREMENT:

Only teams that have successfully completed the official CINERO'26 registration process are eligible to submit films. Film submissions from unregistered teams will not be accepted or considered for the competition.

1.1 ORIGINALITY AND COPYRIGHT

- All submitted films must be original works created by the participating team.
- Submitted films must remain unpublished on all open-access streaming platforms, including YouTube and Facebook, throughout the competition period.
- Music, footage, images, graphics, fonts, and other materials must be original, royalty-free, or properly licensed.
- Participants are responsible for obtaining the necessary permissions for all copyrighted materials used in their films.
- Films must not contain plagiarism or unauthorized use of another person's work.

1.2 LANGUAGE AND SUBTITLES

- All films must include embedded English subtitles so that the judges and audience can understand the content.
- Separate dialogue lists will not be accepted as a replacement for subtitles.

1.3 TECHNICAL REQUIREMENTS

All submitted films must meet the following technical requirements:

- File format: MP4 or MOV
- Resolution: Full HD (1920 × 1080) or higher
- Video codec: H.264
- Audio: 2.0 Stereo

1.4 PROMOTIONAL RIGHTS

- By participating, teams grant CINERO'26 non-exclusive permission to use their film posters, trailers, selected clips, and team photographs for festival-related promotional purposes.
- The original ownership of the films remains with their creators.

1.5 JUDGING AND FINAL DECISIONS

- Films will be evaluated by a panel of judges with relevant filmmaking expertise.
- The judging panel's decisions on awards and rankings will be final.
- The Organizing Committee reserves the right to reject entries that do not comply with the official guidelines.



2. INTER-SCHOOL CATEGORY GUIDELINES

Rules Specifically for School Students



2.1 ELIGIBILITY AND PARTICIPATION

- The competition is open to students currently studying in Grades 6–13 at schools.
- Students who are sitting for or registered for the G.C.E. Advanced Level (A/L) examination are not eligible to participate.
- Each team must represent one eligible school. Students from different schools cannot form a team together.
- Each team must consist of a minimum of 4 members and a maximum of 15 members.
- Each student may participate in only one team.
- Each school or team may submit only one film.
- Participants must provide proof of current student status through a student confirmation letter signed by the school principal.

2.2 TEACHER SUPERVISION

- Each participating school must appoint one teacher as the team's guardian.
- The teacher must supervise and accompany the team throughout the competition and at the award ceremony.

2.3 FILM REQUIREMENTS

- Films must be created on or after 1 January 2026.
- The film must have a running time of 5–15 minutes, including opening and closing credits.
- The topic and genre are open, provided the content is appropriate for school students.
- Films may be produced in any language, but embedded English subtitles are compulsory.
- AI tools may be used only if they do not compromise the film's originality, authenticity, or human creative quality.
- The Organizing Committee may request raw footage, behind-the-scenes videos, project files, or production records to verify the film's creation date.

2.4 EXTERNAL ASSISTANCE

- Professional filmmakers, paid actors, and external production houses must not be involved in producing the submitted film.
- The film must be created by the participating students.

2.5 REGISTRATION AND SUBMISSION

- Registration fee: LKR 2,000 per team.
- Teams must register and submit their films through the official links provided by the Organizing Committee.
- A member of the Organizing Committee will contact the team via WhatsApp or telephone to confirm receipt.
- All submissions must be completed before the official deadline. Late submissions will not be accepted.

2.6 JUDGING AND AWARDS

Films will be evaluated by a panel of judges based on the following criteria:

- Storytelling and screenplay
- Acting and performances
- Directing and creative vision
- Cinematography and visual quality
- Editing and technical execution

Awards will be presented in the following categories:

- Best Director
- Best Screenplay
- Best Actor/Actress (Best Performer)
- Best Cinematographer
- Best Editor
- School-category films will not be publicly screened at the festival venue.
- Winners will receive official awards, trophies, and certificates.
- Cash prizes will not be awarded in the Inter-School category.